Operational Policies and Procedures

104 Golden Lane,

Hutto, TX, 78634

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Hours of Operation

Little Stars Home Daycare hours are from 9.00AM-5.30PM; Monday – Friday; January - December

Admission/Enrollment Procedures

All necessary enrollment forms must be completed and returned prior to admission. It is the parent's responsibility to ensure all forms are updated immediately upon changes and at least once a year. Upon arrival at the **Little Stars Home Daycare** the parent, or adult dropping off the child, must escort the child into the home and ensure that the provider is aware of their presence.

Forms needed:

*Parent Handbook

*Immunization Record

*Permission to Administer Medication

Procedure for Release of Children

The child will ONLY be released to the parent/guardian with legal custody or persons over 18 who are designated by the parent on the Emergency Contact Form. The provider will refuse to release the child to anyone not on the list. The provider will require photo identification from anyone that it is not recognized. The providers will not release the child to anyone including the parents/guardian s if they suspect the person in under the influence of drugs or alcohol, or any other substance that they feel may pose a threat to the child.

Sign In/Sign Out

Parents/guardians are required to sign up for their child each morning and out each afternoon. This serves as a record of attendance in the case of emergency. Every time someone brings in a child or picks up, he or she must sign in/out. Please advise anyone who is dropping off or picking your child up of this policy. To ensure that the provider is in compliance with any court orders pertaining to the custody of the child, the provider requires a certified copy of the custody order. The provider will keep this information confidential and solely for the safety and well-being of the child. If a new custody order is issued or if a restraining order is issued against either parent, the provider will also need this information on file. It is the policy of the provider to remain neutral in all custody maters and the facility may not serve as a visitation site.

Nap Time

One afternoon nap/rest time after lunch with duration of 1 - 2 hours. Parents are supposed to send a nap mat.

Holiday Closings

Little Stars Home Daycare will operate year-round except for the following:

Holidays Observed:

- New Year's Eve & New Years Day
- MLK Day
- Fourth of July
- Memorial Day
- Labor Day
- Thanksgiving Day
- Friday after Thanksgiving
- Christmas Eve
- Christmas Day

Smoking

This is a non-smoking daycare. Smoking is strictly prohibited on the premises. Please inform spouses or those on your pick-up list about the policy.

Health Check

The health and well-being of each child at **Little Stars Home Daycare** is of the utmost importance to us, therefore we will conduct a daily health check at drop off & pick up before the parent's leave. The results of the health check will be determined by care-giver, not the parent, on whether or not the child remains in care for that day. The health check is done as a casual observation at your initial contact with the child. Check for easily observable, simple signs of well-being. The goal of the health check is to know your children are healthy and ready to learn.

Screen Time Policy

Little Stars Home Daycare will allow screen time for children ages 2 years and older for no more than 1 hour per day for education purposes. We do not allow tablets or computers at our daycare

Transportation

No transportation will be provided to pick up/drop off the child.

Illness and Exclusion

If your child exhibits a change in mood or behavior after arriving at the center, a health check may be conducted to determine if your child is ill. The health check may include a visual or physical assessment of the child and/or the use of a thermometer to reveal the child's temperature.

If a child becomes ill, we will attempt to contact the child's parents. If we cannot contact the parents, we will contact the person(s) designated as the emergency contact on the child's admission form and ask them to pick up the child.

Dispensing and Handling Medication

No child will be given any medication, prescription or over the counter, unless the parent gives written permission. Permission to Administer Medication forms are to be filled out each time your child needs medicine to be administered. Prescription medication shall have the child's name, name of medication, doctor's name, name of pharmacy, prescription number, date, and directions for administering. The medication must be in the original container as dispensed by the pharmacy.

Immunization Requirements

For the safety of all the children enrolled, each child enrolled or admitted into **Little Stars Home Daycare** must meet applicable immunization required by the Texas Department of Family and Protective Services and submitted by the date of admission.

Meals

Breakfast is served between 9-9:30 AM. Lunch will be given from 11:30 AM to 12 PM. Afternoon snacks are provided from 1:45-2:15 PM.

Parents can provide lunch for their children.

Handling Medical Emergencies

In the event of an emergency with your child, parents will be called, and if necessary, the child will be transported by ambulance to the nearest hospital.

Discipline and Guidance Policy

Complies with Subchapter L, Discipline and Guidance of the Minimum Standard for Child-Care Centers.

Little Stars Home Daycare uses positive methods of discipline and guidance.

- Discipline will be individualized and consistent for each child, appropriate to the child's level of understanding, and directed toward teaching the child acceptable behavior and self-control.
- A caregiver will only use positive methods of discipline and guidance that encourage self-esteem, self-control, and self-direction, which include at least the following:
    - Using praise and encouragement of good behavior instead of focusing only upon unacceptable behavior.
    - Reminding a child of behavior expectations daily by using clear, positive statements.
    - Redirecting behavior using positive statements
    - Using brief supervised separation or time out from the group, when appropriate for the child's age and development, which is limited to no more than one minute per year of the child's age. **Little Stars Home Daycare** will not use harsh, cruel, or unusual treatment of any child.

Indoor and outdoor physical activity

Children need to be active every day to promote their healthy growth and development. The benefits of Physical Activity everyday will help with:

- Healthy growth and development
- Better self-esteem
- Stronger bones, muscles and joints
- Better posture and balance
- A stronger heart
- A healthier weight range
- Social interaction with friends
- Learning new skills while having fun
- Better focus and concentration during school

We do spend time outside every day, weather permitting. For infants, outside time is 15 minutes in the morning and 15 minutes in the evening, permitting the weather. for all other students 30 minutes in the morning and 30 minutes in the evening permitting weather. some activities that children would do outside would be running in place, playing catches, jumping jacks, jump rope all depending on the weather. indoor activities would be kids exercise, such as jumping jacks, running in place, dance, simon says, etc. during cold weather please provide your child's jackets, sweaters, and/or extra clothes as well as closed toed shoes. Please make sure all belongings are LABELED with your child's name.

Emergency Preparedness Plan

- In case of emergency evacuation or relocation, our/caregivers' responsibility is to move the children to a safe designated area.
- Master Bedroom Closet is the safe location during sheltering/lock-down emergency where children's will gather and its away from windows and doors.
- Carmel Creek Children Swing Park is the address of the alternate shelter away from the home will use as needed.
- Caregiver will take attendance to ensure all children are safely evacuated. If a child is missing, alert first responders.
- Parents will be notified once children are safely relocated, using the emergency contact details provided in enrollment forms.
- Will contact local emergency officials by dialing 911 or 311 and coordinate evacuation efforts with first responders such as fire, law enforcement, emergency medical services, health department.
- Texas Childcare Licensing will also be notified once all children are deemed safe.
- Conduct quarterly lockdown drills to ensure children's should understand where to go and what to do.
- Help keep the children calm by reassuring them and maintaining a sense of routine as much as possible.

Fire:

Get the children out of the house, meet at the designated safe place as far away from house as possible, and conduct a head count to ensure all children are safely out. Call the fire department and call the parents.

Severe Weather:

Remain calm. Move the children into a hallway or interior room away from windows. In case of a tornado, have the children place their heads between their knees with their backs to the wall. Listen to the TV/Mobile for weather updates.

Loss of Electrical Power:

Remain calm. Call the power company to report power loss. If in hot weather, open the windows, if possible. In cooler weather, put on warmer clothing or get blankets out for the children. Call the parents if the power will be out for an extended period of time.

Loss of Water:

Have bottled water available for drinking purposes. Call the City of Hutto water department . Call the plumber. If water will be out for an extended time, have water available for hand washing and toileting purposes. Call the parents if the water will remain out of service for an extended length of time.

Serious Injury to a Child:

Call 911. Keep the child calm and comfortable until medical service arrives. Call the child's parents to report the injury.

Loss of a Child:

Call 911 or the police. Call the child's parent to report the loss. Keep the other children calm. Call the neighbor to help assist in the search. Look in the house, yard, and surrounding area.

Parental Visit

Parents may visit **Little Stars Home Daycare** unannounced and at any time that their child is in care. Any information requested by the parents concerning the operation of the **Little Stars Home Daycare** or the care of the child will be provided to parents. The parent(s) will be provided daily communication (verbal/written) regarding the care of the child.

Parent Notification

Parents of any child who becomes ill or is injured while in care will be notified immediately of any illness or injury requiring professional medical attention, or any illness which may not require professional medical attention but which produces symptoms causing moderate discomfort to the child, such as, but not limited to, any of the following: elevated temperature, vomiting or diarrhea. Special problems or significant developments will be communicated to the parents as soon as they arise.

Texas Penal Code

Little Stars Home Daycare will inform parents verbally that under the Texas Penal Code, any area within 1000 feet of a child-care home is a gang-free zone, where criminal offenses related to organized criminal activity are subject to harsher penalty.

Parents are entitled to see the following information:

- Copy of the most recent inspection report is available upon request and posted in the **Little Stars Home Daycare**.
- **Little Stars Home Daycare** Operational Policies and Procedures (handbook).

Minimum standards and Licensing Inspection Report

A copy of the most recent inspection report and Minimum Standards can be viewed upon request.

In addition, parents can find Minimum Standards online by going to:
https://www.hhs.texas.gov/providers/child-care-regulation/minimum-standards

Preventing and responding to abuse and neglect of children

Texas law requires caregivers to report suspected child abuse or neglect to the Texas Department of Family and Protective Services or law enforcement.

Little Stars Home Daycare will ensure annual training is completed by caregivers to prevent and respond to abuse and neglect of children.

You may also contact **local licensing office** at below address:

14000 Summit Drive
Suite 100, Austin, TX 78728; Contact Number: 512-834-3195

Reports of suspected child abuse may be directed to the Texas Abuse Hotline at 1-800-252-5400 or Texas Abuse Hotline website https://www.txabusehotline.org

The Texas Health and Human Services (HHS) website - https://www.hhs.texas.gov/providers/child-care-regulation also provides information about Child Care Regulation (CCR) and how to report concerns about child care providers.

Recognizing the Signs of Child Abuse

Physical Abuse

Physical Abuse is physical injury that results in substantial harm to the child, or the genuine threat of substantial harm from physical injury to the child. The physical injury (ranging from minor bruises to severe fractures or death) can result from punching, beating, shaking, kicking, biting, throwing, stabbing, hitting, burning, choking, or otherwise harming a child. Such injury is considered abuse regardless of whether the caretaker intended to hurt the child.

Suspect Physical Abuse When You See:

- Frequent injuries such as bruises, cuts, black eyes, or burns without adequate explanations.
- Frequent complaints of pain without obvious injury.
- Burns or bruises in unusual patterns that may indicate the use of an instrument or human bite; cigarette burns on any part of the body.
- Lack of reaction to pain.
- Aggressive, disruptive, and destructive behavior.
- Passive, withdrawn, and emotionless behavior.
- Fear of going home or seeing parents.
- Injuries that appear after a child has not been seen for several days.
- Unreasonable clothing that may hide injuries to arms or legs

Neglect

Neglect is failure to provide for a child's basic needs necessary to sustain the life or health of the child, excluding failure caused primarily by financial inability unless relief services have been offered and refused.

Suspect Neglect When You See

- Obvious malnourishment
- Lack of personal cleanliness

- Torn or dirty clothing
- Stealing or begging for food
- Child unattended for long periods of time
- Need for glasses, dental care, or other medical attention
- Frequent tardiness or absence from school

Sexual Abuse

Sexual Abuse includes fondling a child's genitals, penetration, incest, rape, sodomy, indecent exposure, and exploitation through prostitution or producing pornographic materials.

Suspect Sexual Abuse When You See:

- Physical signs of sexually transmitted diseases
- Evidence of injury to the genital area
- Pregnancy in a young girl
- Difficulty in sitting or walking
- Extreme fear of being alone with adults of a certain sex
- Sexual comments, behaviors or play
- Knowledge of sexual relations beyond what is expected for a child's age
- Sexual victimization of other children

Emotional Abuse

Emotional Abuse is mental or emotional injury that results in an observable and material impairment in a child's growth, development, or psychological functioning. It includes extreme forms of punishment such as confining a child in a dark closet, habitual scapegoating, belittling, and rejecting treatment for a child.

Suspect Emotional Abuse When You See:

- Over compliance
- Low self-esteem
- Severe depression, anxiety, or aggression
- Difficulty making friends or doing things with other children
- Lagging in physical, emotional, and intellectual development
- Caregiver who belittles the child, withholds love, and seems unconcerned about the child's problems